



SHATTERED: (L-R) Swaraj, Rajnath, Advani and Vajpayee with Shekhawat in the country to debate about a choice made by the UPA". All too conscious of the criticism, Patil's first words as President were, "I hope to live up to the high expectations of the people who elected me."

The stakes are equally high for the Congress. The next six Assembly elections will be fought between the Congress and BJP. Currently BJP is ruling in Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan, while the Congress holds sway over Delhi and Himachal Pradesh. With the next general elections coming up in two years' time, both the national parties were keen to get a favourable candidate in the Rashtrapati Bhavan. After all, it is the President who decides whom to invite to form the next government.

For the moment, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh is content to remark that Patil's election is a victory of the

ruling alliance over divisive forces. His colleagues in the Congress also see this as a victory over some of its own allies. UPA partners were not happy with Patil's candidature, but they all ended up voting for her. Initially, as the allegations were mounting, the Left kept its distance claiming that Patil was UPA's candidate and not a joint UPA-Left nominee. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat tersely told reporters to direct all their queries to Sonia. But the Congress played hardball. And soon, both CPI(M) politburo member Sitaram Yechury and CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan were defending Patil to the media. When there were doubts about NCP chief Sharad Pawar's loyalties, the Maratha leader was roped in to defend the charges against Patil. All the UPA allies were also showcased at a press conference in the Capital. Wannabe presidential candidates from the Congress, Pranab Mukherjee and Arjun Singh, were also on the dais to profess unity and support for Sonia's choice.

This overdrive was not exactly uncalled for. By targeting Patil's stature and credentials, BJP was also questioning Sonia's ability to make the right choice, prompting Congress managers to ensure an overwhelming victory. With BJP blowing up Sonia's penchant for appointing 'loyalists' to the country's top jobs, the prestige of their party president was at stake. Sonia took a personal interest in the campaign, meeting MPs and coaching them on how to sign the ballot paper. She wanted to ensure no vote was wasted. As Patil was the first choice, Congress MPs were told specifically that they had to write the numerical figure '1'—or, like "Gandhiji's lathi", as Sonia told an MP from Gujarat—and not in words.

In the end, the Congress got the victory it worked for. It didn't matter that Patil chose an auspicious time to take oath. During the swearing-in ceremony, when a cell phone caller tune, *Ajeeb dastan hai yeh*, rang out, it was difficult to tell which Madam President was smiling the most. ■